



[Course](#) > [4. Reporting your findings](#) > [4.2 Structuring your report](#) > Structuring your paragraphs

Structuring your paragraphs

🔖 Bookmark this page

Now that your research has been divided, first into chapters and then into sections, we will zoom in on these sections. Each section has a single purpose, and will contain a body of text. This body of text would be very hard to read if all sentences follow one another immediately. Instead, it is structured into paragraphs.

Each paragraph communicates a single idea to the reader. Generally, this idea is covered in one *topic sentence*, which captures the main point of the paragraph. The rest of the paragraph expands on this point, and explains or supports the topic sentence. Often, the topic sentence occurs as one of the first sentences of a paragraph, but it may appear at other positions as well.

When going over your own paragraphs, ask yourself the following questions:

- Does this paragraph have a single topic?
- Is this paragraph coherent? Do the sentences logically follow each other?
- Does this paragraph make its point completely and concisely?

Exercise A

1/1 point (graded)

The paragraph below consists of 4 sentences. However, the sentences are not ordered logically.

[1] *Geothermal wells release greenhouse gases trapped deep within the earth, but these emissions are much lower per energy unit than those of fossil fuels.* **[2]** *This development makes applications such as home heating more feasible, opening a potential for widespread exploitation.* **[3]** *Geothermal power has the potential to help mitigate global warming if widely deployed in place of fossil fuels.* **[4]** *Although geothermal energy historically has been limited to areas near tectonic plate boundaries, recent technological advances have dramatically expanded the range and size of viable resources.*

Pursue a verified certificate

Upgrade Now (\$49)



☐ [3]-[4]-[1]-[2];☒ [3]-[1]-[4]-[2]; ✓☐ [4]-[2]-[1]-[3];☐ [4]-[2]-[3]-[1].

Answer

Correct:

The order [3]-[1]-[4]-[2] leads to the most logical storyline for this paragraph. Sentence [3] is most suitable as a topic sentence. A topic sentence covers the main thought/idea of a paragraph and/or clarifies the paragraph's structure. Preferably, the topic sentence is the first sentence of the paragraph. A text in which each paragraph contains the topic sentence, allows a reader to scan the text quickly and still obtain the main information. It helps the reader to understand the overall storyline and coherence of a section or chapter. In this example, sentence [3] covers the main idea of the paragraph best and seems to summarize the information from sentences [1], [2] and [4]. Sentence [1] provides support for the statement that the use geothermal energy is more sustainable than the use of fossil fuels. Sentences [4] and [2] (in that order) support the notion that it can now be widely used.

Submit

You have used 1 of 3 attempts

i Answers are displayed within the problem

Exercise B

1/1 point (graded)

Read the paragraph below.

A geothermal heat pump can extract enough heat from shallow ground anywhere in the world to provide home heating, but industrial applications need the higher temperatures of deep resources [13]. The thermal efficiency and profitability of electricity generation is particularly sensitive to temperature. The most demanding applications receive the greatest benefit from a high natural heat flux, ideally from using a hot spring. The next best option is to drill a well into a hot aquifer. If no adequate aquifer is available, an artificial one may be built by injecting water to hydraulically fracture the bedrock. This last approach is called hot dry rock geothermal energy in Europe, or enhanced geothermal systems in North America. Much greater potential may be available from this approach than from conventional tapping of natural aquifers [32].

Based on text retrieved from Wikipedia: *Geothermal energy*. Retrieved 13-4-2017 from https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Geothermal_energy. Edited and

Pursue a verified certificate

Upgrade Now (\$49)



Which of the options below would be the best topic sentence to start the paragraph with?
Multiple answers can be correct.

- ☐ To use geothermal energy for industrial applications, various options are available;
- ☐ Generally, several technological solutions are available to use geothermal energy for industrial applications;
- ☒ The technological solutions available to use geothermal energy for industrial applications vary in their effectiveness; ✓
- ☐ This paragraph should be divided into at least two new paragraphs in order to write a good topic sentence. ✓

Answer

Correct:

A good paragraph should be about a single idea. In this case, it seems that the writer has various ideas to convey: (1) there is a difference between industrial and household application of geothermal energy, (2) various technological solutions are available for these applications and (3) these solutions all vary in their potential effectiveness. It could be argued that the third topic sentence is the best option, as it makes an effort to combine these three ideas. However, the fourth answer might be a good option too. If a paragraph contains multiple ideas and it is not clear what the main idea is it should cover, it can be a more informative to divide it into multiple paragraphs. In this case, perhaps the writer could first spend a paragraph on explaining the differences between household and industrial applications. After that, the next paragraph could explain the technological solutions for industrial applications and their effectiveness.

Submit

You have used 2 of 3 attempts

i Answers are displayed within the problem

Next, an opportunity for questions about structuring your report.

© All Rights Reserved



Pursue a verified certificate

Upgrade Now (\$49)



 English ▼

© 2012-2017 edX Inc. All rights reserved except where noted. EdX, Open edX and the edX and Open EdX logos are registered trademarks or trademarks of edX Inc. | 粤ICP备17044299号-2

POWERED BY
OPENedX



Pursue a verified certificate

Upgrade Now (\$49)

